where one could well ask whether the idea of a cohesive Western world is tenable any more. The glue which bound this framework together was the US. As that country now turns increasingly inwards, this is threatening to come unstuck. What we may therefore be seeing is an emerging multipolarity within the West. When such a West engages India, or the other way around, it is going to be different from the days when its solidarity was stronger.

India may be a rising power but it clearly still has a great distance to go. There are, however, lessons from contemporary history that it can take into account. The fact is that the most impressive growth stories of the last 150 years have all been with the participation of the West. This was true of Japan in the nineteenth century and after 1950, of South Korea in the 1960s, of the ASEAN in the 1970s and of China in the 1980s and thereafter. Even the Soviet Union had Germany as a critical partner in the 1920s to industrialize rapidly. In China's case, it reaped a double benefit from a double risk – going first with the USSR in the 1950s and then switching to the West in the 1980s. It goes without saying that the West would have its own agenda in doing so. But for its partners, the challenge is to utilize that option and handle its consequences.

What India stands to gain is fairly obvious. A stronger partnership with the West will lead to considerable political benefits and economic gains, though both would have to be balanced by Indian equities in competing constituencies. Looking just beyond the horizon, there are also immense opportunities to be exploited in terms of technology applications and human resources optimization. Globalization may currently be under some stress due to some distortions, but it will manifest itself in a revised form. While it can be asserted with some confidence that a combination of economics, technology and demographics will draw India and the West closer, the real difference would be made by politics and values. For it to succeed in good measure, India and the West must fit into each other's scheme of the world. Envisaging India's growth as a strategic development in the larger Western interest is a starting point. Such thinking has become more accepted in the US and Japan; it still has to develop more in Europe.